tion goes to the original landowner.

At Sindhudurg's Devgad, home of the famed Devgad Alphonso, former MLA and third-generation farmer Ajit Gogate says this has been the "worst season" for mango growers. "While farmers have spent on growth regulators, pesticides and manpower, poor yields have shrunk their earnings," says Gogate, chairman of the Devgad Taluka Amba Utpadak Sahakari Sanstha Maryadit. Other growers point to compounding setbacks. Jaywant Lad, for instance, says the failure of the first flush has come as a double whammy, as mangoes that reach the market in February-March command a premium.

ROOTS OF THE CRISIS

Experts and growers trace the current crisis to a mix of climatic shifts and flawed practices. Dr Vivek Bhide, president, Konkan Hapus Amba Utpadak Aani Vikrete Sahkari Sanstha, Ratnagiri, says this disaster was in the making for years. "The onset of Cyclone Phyan in 2009 had led to rapid changes in climatic conditions. Mango production has been fluctuating since 2010," he adds. "Since the 1990s, mango plantations have grown. But while the acreage increased, the yield has failed to keep pace," explains Bhide, adding that modern methods of grafting are faulty. Bhide also blames the excessive use of pesticides and growth regulators, which boost reproductive growth while hindering vegetative growth, for the situation, noting that it has harmed pollinators like bees. He also points to the unbridled felling of *raywal* (wild/*desi*) mango trees—for timber, Hapus monoculture and even during the Holi festival—which has reduced cross-pollination.

Kiran Malshe, a horticulturist at Dapoli-based Balasaheb Sawant Konkan Krishi Vidyapeeth, echoes Bhide's argument on the harm to pollinators. He also attributes lower fruiting to the monsoon, which lasted till November, and a drop in the minimum temperature in winter. Since the first flowering had been intense, the ability of the trees to bear fruit in the next two flushes had declined. But Chandrakant Mokal, president of the Maharashtra State Mango Growers Association, cites rising pollution, including emissions from local chemical industries, as a key factor for the crisis. Kulkarni in Nivendi vouches for that, linking his crop failure to a coal-based thermal power plant in the vicinity.

In March, thousands of angry mango cultivators blocked the arterial Mumbai-Goa highway in Sindhudurg, protesting the state government's compensation of Rs 22,000 per hectare, which translates to a meagre Rs 220 per tree, given that a hectare has about 100 trees. Claiming that maintaining an acre of orchards with 40 trees costs over Rs 3 lakh—including labour, fertilisers and multiple rounds of pesticide spraying to tackle recurring infestations of pests such as the mango hopper and thrips—farmers demanded Rs 5 lakh per hectare and threatened to march to chief minister Devendra Fadnavis's residence in Mumbai in protest. Nitesh Rane, minister for ports and fisheries, and guardian minister for Sindhudurg, said he had urged Fadnavis to increase the compensation, but a decision is still pending.

The fallout is visible in the market. Traders at the Agricultural Produce Market Committee in Vashi, Navi Mumbai, which handles around 60 per cent of the Konkan's mango arrivals, say average daily volumes had fallen to about 40,000 boxes early this month, from 80,000 last year. Though volumes have improved to around 60,000 boxes this week, the supply is expected to taper beginning mid-May. Farmers allege that traders are citing the war in the Middle East and disrupted logistics lines as a pretext to buy mangoes at



"THE ONSET OF CYCLONE PHYAN IN 2009 LED TO RAPID CHANGES IN CLIMATIC CONDITIONS. PRODUCTION HAS BEEN FLUCTUATING SINCE 2010"

DR VIVEK BHIDE
President, Konkan Hapus Amba Utpadak Aani Vikrete Sahkari Sanstha, Ratnagiri

274,949 tonnes — **ALPHONSO OUTPUT IN THE KONKAN IN 2025**

WHY ALPHONSO IS SPECIAL

Among the finest table mangoes, it is known for its sweetness, rich flavour, with a smooth, creamy pulp

DEVGAD VARIETY

- Larger than Ratnagiri fruit; stronger aroma
- Bright yellow skin; firm, low-fibre pulp
- Does not drip much juice due to lower moisture

RATNAGIRI VARIETY

- Broadly similar traits to Devgad Alphonso
- Generally smaller in size
- Lower stone weight, resulting in more pulp

WHAT WENT WRONG THIS YEAR

- Rains till November disrupted flowering cycle
- Sub-10°C temperatures hit pollination
- Wide max-min temperature gaps stressed crop
- Heavy dew triggered fungal blackening
- Excess early flowering drained trees
- All three flowering cycles hit
- Excessive pesticides harmed bees
- Felling of wild mango trees hurt cross-pollination
- Industrial and infra pollution impacted vegetation